Managing Stress
For Everyone
May 12, 2026
Español
Get help now
If you or someone you know is struggling or in crisis, confidential, free, 24/7/365 help is available. Call or text 988 or chat 988lifeline.org. See Resources for help.

Key points
Everyone experiences occasional stress; it is a normal part of life.
Long-term stress can lead to worsening health problems.
Managing stress daily can prevent you from developing long-term stress.
Find resources if you are struggling to cope with stress for extra support.
A woman sitting in a garden, eyes closed, hands folded across her chest. Above her, a watering can is pouring a rainbow.
How it impacts everyday life
Everyone experiences stress, which is your body's physical and emotional response to new or challenging situations.1 This can occur when you face problems such as those related to work, school, health, and relationships. Feeling stress can be a normal coping response and can forge a healthy sense of our ability to solve problems. However, when the stress is long term, known as chronic stress, it can lead to worsening health problems.2

Stress can cause the following:

Feelings of fear, anger, sadness, worry, numbness, or frustration
Changes in appetite, energy, desires, and interests
Trouble concentrating and making decisions
Nightmares or problems sleeping
Physical reactions, such as headaches, body pains, stomach problems, or skin rashes
Worsening of chronic health problems and mental health conditions
Increased use of alcohol, drugs, and other substances
Healthy ways to cope with stress
Learning to cope in a healthy way can help reduce your stress. Taking small steps in your daily life to manage stress can have a big impact. Everyone manages stress differently. You can find and manage what triggers your stress and the right combination of healthy techniques that work for you.

Take care of your mind.

Take breaks from news and social media. It is good to be informed, but constant information about negative events can be upsetting.3
Make time to unwind.
Take deep breaths, stretch, or meditate.
Keep a journal.

Spend time outdoors either being active or relaxing.
Try to do some other relaxing activities you enjoy.
Practice gratitude daily. Remind yourself of specific things you are grateful for and write them down.4
Connect with others.
Talk with people you trust about your concerns and how you are feeling.
Connect with your community-based or faith-based organizations.
Gratitude works
Woman with bandana drinking from a mug
Gratitude may be the best kept secret to help reduce stress and feel better. Practicing gratitude every day can improve your physical and emotional well-being.
Take care of your body.

Get enough sleep. Go to bed and wake up at the same time each day to help you sleep better. Adults need 7 or more hours per night.5
Move more. Staying physically healthy can improve your emotional well-being. Every little bit of physical activity helps.
Start small and build up to 2 ½ hours a week.
Break it into smaller amounts such as 20 to 30 minutes a day.
Eat healthy. Have fruits and vegetables, lean protein, whole grains, and low-fat or no-fat dairy.
Limit foods with unhealthy fats, salt, and added sugars. See Healthy Eating Tips.
Limit alcohol intake. Choose not to drink, or drink in moderation on days you drink alcohol.
Moderation means:
2 drinks or less a day for men.
1 drink or less for women.
Find out more at Drink Less, Be Your Best.
Avoid using illegal drugs or prescription drugs in ways other than prescribed. Don't take someone else's prescription. Substance use treatment is available, and recovery starts with asking for help.
Avoid smoking, vaping, and the use of other tobacco products. People can and do quit smoking for good.
Continue with regular health appointments, tests, screenings, and vaccinations.
Integration of physical and mental health
Two women holding weights and walking up stairs
Regular physical activity is one of the most important things you can do for your health and can improve your mental health. See how to get started.
Resources and support
Resources
CDC's Improve Your Emotional Well-Being
CDC's How to Cope with Your Feelings (Emergency Preparedness and Disability Inclusion)
Tools for Supporting Emotional Wellbeing in Children and Youth
I'm So Stressed Out! Fact Sheet (NIMH)
Stress: MedlinePlus
Caring for Your Mental Health - National Institute of Mental Health (NIMH) (nih.gov)